
PART 3 Reading Comprehension

In this section of the test, you will read some texts and answer 42 questions. Choose the correct answer to each question and mark the letter of the correct answer on your answer sheet.

Questions 1-6

You are going to read a newspaper article about an adventure centre. For questions choose the answer (A, B, C or D) which you think fits best according to the text.

I'm focused. Completely terrified, but focused. I've got a tiny area to stand on and beneath me is a 10-metre drop. To make things worse, the totem pole that I'm trying to climb onto is shaking. With one knee bent on the top of the pole and the other foot next to it, I slowly stand up with my arms outstretched for balance. Once upright, my legs are still wobbling but an enormous smile has spread across my face. I shuffle my toes over the edge. And then I jump. Back on the ground, my knees won't stop quaking. But for the boys at Head 4 Heights, an aerial adventure centre in Cirencester, it's all in a day's work.

Head 4 Heights, one of the tallest climbing centres in Britain, opening two years ago. It's the only UK climbing centre open to the public year-round (the only days it closes are when winds exceed 70 mph, almost enough to blow you off a totem pole and into one of the lakes). The course was set up by Rod Baber, adventurer extraordinaire and holder of the world record for scaling the highest peak of every country in Europe in the shortest time. Rod's latest plan is to snag the record for North and South America as well, but in between he starts every day with a clamber round the Cirencester course.

Although the course is only roughly the size of a tennis court, it packs a lot into a small space. There are four totem poles (of varying degrees of difficulty according to the holds attached to them), a stairway to heaven (a giant ladder with an increasing distance between the rungs), two freefall platforms and a trapeze jump. Plans for a new 30-metre pole are presently under way. All can be made easier or harder, according to ability, and incorporated into different challenges, which is why the course has proved a success with families, corporate days out and the centre now averages about 1,500 visitors a month.

All ages over five are welcome, but children are the most enthusiastic and 'far easier to teach than the bankers,' says Rod. Parents are usually more reluctant to join in. 'We hear all sorts of excuses,' says Rod. 'Everything from bad knees to "I haven't trimmed my toenails".' The oldest customer was a 78-year-old

who arrived with his son and grandson. When the younger two **decided to give it a miss**, the grandfather set off to show them how it was done.

For the most part, though, people start off nervous and only gain confidence as they progress. ‘Everything is kept very positive. We always tell people to look up not down and to take their time,’ says Rod. ‘We want to push people outside their comfort zone and into the adventure zone, but we don’t want people to be pushed into the panic zone, which can be mentally damaging.’

Also reassuring is the 100 per cent safety record. The course was designed and built by Nick Moriarty, an expert in his field who has constructed 450 courses in 16 countries and trained 2,700 instructors. Key to the design is the safety-rope system, which ensures that if you do lose your balance or grip, your full-body harness will guarantee that you float, not fall, back to earth.

1. One problem the writer describes in the first paragraph is that

- (A) She keeps falling off the totem pole.
- (B) She is trying to stand on top of a moving object.
- (C) She cannot get her arms into the right position.
- (D) She is too nervous to complete the climb.

2. What do we learn about Head 4 Heights in the second paragraph?

- (A) It remains open even in quite windy conditions.
- (B) Rod Baber got the idea for it while climbing mountains.
- (C) It did not initially stay open throughout the year.
- (D) It is aimed at people who don’t have the chance to climb mountains.

3. The writer says that the main reason for the course’s popularity is that

- (A) The challenges it offers cannot be found anywhere else.
- (B) New challenges are constantly being added.
- (C) It can be completed in a fairly short time.

(D) It can be adapted for different people.

4. The people who ‘decided to give it a miss’ are examples of people who

- (A) Find it difficult to do the course.
- (B) Are unwilling to do the course.
- (C) Are easily taught how to do the course.
- (D) Give up while they are doing course.

5. Rod says that the intention of the course is that people taking part

- (A) Learn how to deal with extreme fear.
- (B) Progress as quickly as possible.
- (C) Take risks they might not initially want to take.
- (D) Increase in confidence after repeated visits.

6. The writer uses the phrase ‘Also reassuring’ to emphasize

- (A) That people benefit from doing the course.
- (B) How carefully the course has been constructed.
- (C) That people should not be afraid to do the course.
- (D) How enthusiastic Rod is about the course.

Questions 7-12

You are going to read an extract from a novel. For questions, choose the answer (A, B, C or D) which you think fits best according to the text.

The Fulton Chain Floating Library is only a tiny room, a closet really, below decks in Charlie Eckler's pickle boat. It is nothing like the proper library they have in Old Forge, but it has its own element of surprise. Mr. Eckler uses the room to store his wares, and when he finally gets round to moving a chest of tea or a sack of cornmeal, you never know what you might find. And regularly, the main library in Herkimer sends up a new book or two. It's nice to get your hands on a new book before everyone else does. While the pages are still clean and white and the spine hasn't been snapped.

I stepped onto the boat and went below decks. The *House of Mirth* was under *W*, like Mr. Eckler said it would be, only it was wedged next to *Mrs. Wiggs of the Cabbage Patch*. Mr. Eckler sometimes gets authors and titles confused. I signed it out in a ledger he kept on top of a molasses barrel, then rooted around behind a crate of eggs, a jam of marbles and a box of dried dates but found nothing I hadn't already read. I remembered to get the bag of cornmeal we needed. I wished I could buy oatmeal or white flour instead, but cornmeal cost less and went further. I was to get a ten-pound bag. The fifty-pound bag cost more to buy but was cheaper per pound and I'd told Pa so, but he said only rich people can afford to be thrifty.

Just as I was about to climb back upstairs, something caught my eye – a box of composition books. Real pretty ones with hard covers on them, and swirly paint designs, and a ribbon to mark your down, and Mrs. Wharton too, and picked one up. Its pages were smooth and white. I thought it would be a fine thing to write on paper that nice. The pages in my old composition book were rough and had blurry blue lines printed on them, and were made with so little care that there were slivers of wood visible in them.

I handed Mr. Eckler fifty cents of my father's money for the cornmeal. 'How much is this?' I asked, holding up one of the pretty composition books. I had sixty cents from all the fiddleheads Weaver and I had sold to the Eagle Bay Hotel. It was money I knew I should have given to my pa. I'd meant to, really. I just hadn't gotten around to it.

'Those notebooks? They're expensive, Mattie. Italians made them. I've got to get forty-five cents apiece,' he said. 'I've got some others coming in for fifteen cents in a week or so if you can wait.'

Forty-five cents was a good deal of money, but I didn't want the ones for fifteen cents, not after I'd seen the others. I had ideas. Tons of them. For stories and poems. I chewed the inside of my cheek, deliberating. I knew I would have to write a lot when I went to Barnard College – *if* I went to Barnard College – and it might be a good idea to get a head start. Weaver had said I should be using my words, not just collecting them, and I knew they would just glide across this beautiful paper, and when I was done writing them, I could close them safely inside the covers. Just like a real book. Guilt gnawed at my insides. I took the money from my pocket and gave it to Mr. Eckler quickly, so the thing was done and I couldn't change my mind.

7. **What does Mattie say about the library in Mr. Eckler's boat?**

- (A) New books are frequently added to it.
- (B) All the books in it are in excellent condition.
- (C) It contains books that are hidden from view.
- (D) Mr. Eckler doesn't know exactly what is in it.

8. **When Mattie found the new book, she**

- (A) Discovered that there were other new books nearby.
- (B) Saw that it had been put in the wrong place.
- (C) Followed Mr. Eckler's system for borrowing books.
- (D) Had to move something so that she could find it.

9. **What was the situation concerning the cornmeal?**

- (A) Her father was unable to save money by buying the bigger bag.
- (B) Her father could not see the point of buying the bigger bag.
- (C) Her father felt that cornmeal was better than oatmeal or white flour.
- (D) Her father had decided to stop buying what he usually bought.

10. **One reason why Mattie liked the look of the composition books was that**

- (A) The covers were shiny.
- (B) The pages were completely clear.
- (C) The pages were thicker than in her old book.
- (D) They had better ribbons than her old book.

11. **When Mattie asked Mr. Eckler how much the composition books cost, he said that**

- (A) They weren't really worth the money.
- (B) They were not the books he had been expecting to receive.
- (C) He did not expect many people to buy them.
- (D) He had no choice about how much to charge for them.

12. **While she was buying one of the books, Mattie thought about**

- (A) How she could use it for making lists of words.
- (B) What the experience of writing in it would be like.
- (C) What people at Barnard College would think of it.
- (D) Whether she would have enough ideas to fill the whole book.

Questions 13-17 refer to the following article.

Look around your office, cubicle, or desk. Have you had the same five pictures up ever since you started working there? Is that a picture of you and your loved one clearly from the early 90s? Does the color scheme consist mainly of beiges, white, and browns? Is the ambient noise mainly coming from the busy street outside, and your co-workers' loud phone conversations? If you can answer "yes" to one or more of these questions, it's time for an office makeover!

One way to definitely **brighten** up your work environment is to bring in some photographs that remind you of wonderful times you've shared with family or friends. When you're in the middle of a ten-hour work day, glancing up and remembering that vacation to Dubai can help put a smile on your face, and motivate

you to keep going. Also, research has consistently shown that mood is directly influenced by color. For example, yellow has been proven to promote joyful moods, and greens and blues can bring about calm. Lastly, music can be an excellent way to improve your work days. We recommend some upbeat or relaxing music, such as jazz, or classical.

Happy makeover!

13. What is the article mainly about?

- (A) Noise reduction
- (B) Changing jobs
- (C) Old pictures should be thrown away
- (D) Improving the work environment

14. According to the article, what office noise may be negative?

- (A) Jazz
- (B) Busy workers
- (C) People talking
- (D) Classical music

15. In the article, the word *brighten* in paragraph 2 is closest in meaning to

- (A) Make more personal

- (B) Make more cheerful
- (C) Make more recognizable
- (D) Make more space

16. Why should workers bring in photographs from home?

- (A) They are friendly.
- (B) They motivate people to spring clean.
- (C) They make long days easier.
- (D) They are environmentally friendly.

17. Why is green a good color?

- (A) It is happy.
- (B) It is fun.
- (C) It is relaxing.
- (D) It is exciting.

Questions 18-21 refer to the following article.

In speech given yesterday in front of City Hall, Governor Thistle explained the budget cuts he would like to introduce this year. He also described ideas for raising new funds without raising taxes.

Firstly, to the dismay of many present, Thistle's first method of saving money is to cut funding to higher education, reducing state aid to all 20 of the colleges and universities by 50 percent. Since these schools are already finding it difficult to compete with schools located in states with more money, and trailing far behind private schools in our own state, this news came as a shock.

However, the second-term governor followed this news by introducing a method for how 14 of these institutions of higher learning could replace the lost funds –gas. According to Thistle, there are impressive amounts of natural gas deposits under these schools. In addition, extracting this gas would bring millions of dollars to the schools that choose to cooperate.

Critics of the plan were quick to speak up. This form of natural gas extraction is well known for creating dangerous environmental consequences. The most harmful of these is the method of waste-water disposal; to date, no 100 percent safe way of getting rid of the **toxic** by-product has been found. In every area where

natural gas has been extracted using the techniques described by Governor Thistle, the surrounding ground water has been polluted.

In short, the Governor wants to give less money to public colleges and universities, while polluting the environment at the same time. A community meeting about this will be held next Thursday at 7:00 p.m. at George Hall.

18. Why are public colleges and universities trailing other educational institutions?

- (A) Other states have more money for their schools.
- (B) Funding will be reduced by 50 percent.
- (C) Private schools hire better professors.
- (D) They did not know gas was underground.

19. How did the audience react to the governor's plan?

- (A) Negatively
- (B) Quietly
- (C) Proudly

(D) Analytically

20. In the article, the word "toxic" in paragraph 4, is closest in meaning to

- (A) Expensive
- (B) Poisonous
- (C) Known
- (D) Garbage

21. According to the article, what will most likely happen if the governor's plan is approved?

- (A) It will pass on Thursday.
- (B) Schools will save money.
- (C) People will protest.
- (D) The water will become polluted.

Questions 22-26 refer to the following article.

Last week we asked our readers to complete an online survey about work and jobs. Surprisingly, over 1,000 of you responded, and we can now reveal the findings.

The most fascinating result was that almost all of you are currently working – in fact, over 89%. Contrary to popular thought, the likelihood of finding employment did not increase with more education. High school graduates who contacted us were just as likely to have a job as respondents with Master's degrees. Not only that, but 95% of people working said that they were satisfied with their jobs.

However, job satisfaction, it seems, does not lead to complacency. Over 50% of you, regardless of whether or not you had a job, said that you had searched for work in the past six months. Our survey also had a question regarding the reasons for doing a job search, and the most popular reason was "higher pay," followed by "better work environment" and, thirdly, "less commuting time."

When those with jobs were asked how their current job was found, the number one response was “networking,” while “ConnektIn.com” claimed the second spot, and, “classifieds” actually came in fifth. It seems traditional methods of finding work no longer apply in today’s job market.

For the complete results of this survey, [click here](#).

22. Where would this article be found?

- (A) A personal website
- (B) A science journal
- (C) A print newspaper
- (D) An online magazine

23. What was the most surprising about the survey respondents?

- (A) The more highly educated had more work.
- (B) Many had Master’s degrees.
- (C) A majority are employed.
- (D) High school graduates were more likely to have jobs.

24. Who said that they had done a job hunt in the last six months?

- (A) Half of the people surveyed

- (B) High school graduates
- (C) Only the unemployed
- (D) People unsatisfied with their job

25. What was one reason NOT mentioned for job hunting?

- (A) Nicer office atmosphere
- (B) Get more education
- (C) Higher salary
- (D) Less travel time

26. According to the article, how did most people find jobs?

- (A) Updating resume
- (B) Contacting friends and associates
- (C) Chatting online
- (D) Being computer literate

Questions 27-30 refer to the following advertisement.

Frank's Driving Vacations

Anywhere you want to go at prices you can afford

Limousines Vans Cars Trucks Trailers Buses

Who can afford their own car these days? Don't waste your money on insurance, gas, and maintenance. Use that money for a fun vacation, and arrive at your destination in style!

Here's what's waiting for you this holiday weekend:

Families: Camping and fireworks in Hoola Canyon. Rent one of our trucks and a trailer, and take your time driving up there. Your kids will enjoy stopping along the way to explore the beautiful countryside! **ONLY \$22 A DAY**

Couples: Choose any of the Hampton Steak House locations around the city, and reserve a table for you and your loved one. Then call Frank's and book a luxurious stretch limo for the evening. (Don't forget to mention using Frank's Car Service when paying your bill at the steak house, and you'll receive 10% off.) Keep the limo for the weekend, and spend a night or two at a country hotel for a romantic gateway. **ONLY \$45 A DAY**

Book your vehicle before Friday – they're going fast!

Call 555-CAR-TOGO, or visit www.frankscars.com

For a full list of prices and services.

27. According to the advertisement, what do people waste money on?

- (A) Buying cars
- (B) Eating steak
- (C) Vacationing with family
- (D) Buying fireworks

28. What costs \$22 a day?

- (A) A hike in Hoola Canyon
- (B) Camping
- (C) A truck and trailer
- (D) Fireworks

29. Why is it a good idea for couples to eat at the Hampton Steak House?

- (A) They have special parking for limousines
- (B) It is conveniently located
- (C) They get 10% off the limousine price
- (D) They get a discount if they used Frank's Car Service

30. What can be seen on Frank's website?

- (A) Restaurant coupons
- (B) Vehicle rates
- (C) Gas prices
- (D) Vacation plans

Questions 31-35 refer to the following letter.

June 5th 2012

Mrs. Julie Evans

46 7th Ave.
St. Louis, MO 63101

Dear Mrs. Evans,

I am applying for the Editor position that was posted on joblist.com the week of June 1st. My experience in the field of publishing, and my educational background makes me an ideal candidate for the job.

My most recent position, before relocating to St. Louis, was with Reason Publishing in New York. I started as an Executive Assistant, but after one year in the position I began to take on more editorial duties. Six months later, I was promoted to Editorial Assistant and oversaw many of the new science fiction titles we published in this period. Before working for Reason Publishing, I had an editing job at Ballard's Monthly, the oldest and most well-respected science fiction journal in the country. I also reviewed new novels for the journal. In all of these jobs, my eye for detail, and ability to meet deadlines made me a valued employee.

Beyond my work experience, my educational background and personal character are also relevant. I graduated at the top of my class from New York University with a double major in English Literature and Journalism. Additionally, I read all genres of fiction voraciously, and have a great eye for new talent.

Also, as any work colleague or personal acquaintance will attest, I am extremely calm under pressure, and always have an optimistic attitude.

I am available for an interview at your convenience, and can be reached at the phone number or email above.

Sincerely,

Faisal Jones

31. What type of letter is this?

- (A) A letter of complaint
- (B) A cover letter for a job
- (C) A letter to request information
- (D) An apology letter

32. How did Faisal find out about the job?

- (A) Bulletin board notice
- (B) From a friend
- (C) Classifieds website
- (D) In the newspaper

33. How long after starting with Reason Publishing was Faisal promoted?

- (A) 18 months

(B) Six months

(C) Two years

(D) One year

34. What was one of Faisal's responsibilities at Ballard's Monthly?

- (A) Designing science fiction books
- (B) Setting deadlines for authors
- (C) Writing science fiction novels
- (D) Reviewing new novels

35. What hobby does Faisal believe to help him at work?

- (A) He writes short stories
- (B) He watches science fiction films

(C) He listens to all genres of music

(D) He reads a variety of books

Questions 36-40 refer to the following article.

Three of the highest scoring basketball players of all time sat down in a pizza restaurant last night to discuss their latest wins and losses. They were all very excited to be meeting face-to-face. “We’ve been through some amazing times together,” said Kai Tsai.

The bespectacled teenagers at the table certainly did not look like professional basketball players. That’s because they are only pros in the **virtual** world of NBA2U, an online game where you choose to be one player for a whole season, and then try and win the championship. The players are then drafted by coaches, and games are played against opponents from all over the world. In real life, these three boys are all in their last year at high school, and are looking forward to attending university in the fall. And none of them has ever played on a real basketball team.

The three young men did not realize they were all such high-level players in the same virtual community until last night, when a party was hosted in Chicago for the most elite players of NBA2U. The **get-together** was well-attended, with over 500 guests. There are millions that attend virtual NBA parties, so these 500 were carefully selected. Guests ranged in age from 12 to 72, and were representing over 25 countries.

After finishing his last bite of pizza, Kai admitted, “I wish I could spend all my time playing NBA2U. It’s much cooler than real life. “As they all spend at least three hours a day in the game, these kids might not realize how “cool” real life can be.

36. Why did the three boys meet up at the pizza parlor?

- (A) To play NBA2U
- (B) To discuss a game
- (C) To play basketball
- (D) To talk about a party

37. In the article, the word *virtual* in paragraph 2 is closest in meaning to

- (A) Talented
- (B) Fake
- (C) Computer-generated
- (D) Real

38. How do you begin playing the game?

- (A) Pay a small fee
- (B) Play the championship game
- (C) Choose a player

(D) Choose a team

39. In the article, the word *get-together* in paragraph 3 is closest in meaning to

- (A) Dinner
- (B) Party
- (C) Competition
- (D) Team

40. Where does Kai want to spend his time?

- (A) On a real basketball court
- (B) At school
- (C) Online
- (D) At university